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Music Appreciation

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Critical Music Review

The second concert of the Charlotte Symphony Al Fresco series took place on June 17, 2020, as an outdoor classical music performance in a patio-style setting. The concert was divided into two halves, which helped organize the different pieces that were performed. The space looked like a relaxed outdoor area where people could gather and enjoy live music together if it hadn't been in the time of the COVID-19 pandemic. Even though the area itself was pretty spacious, the seating and performance space were arranged closer together, which made the concert feel more personal and connected. Overall, the concert demonstrated how classical musicians adapted to the challenges of the COVID-19 pandemic while still maintaining strong musical expression, technical skill, and audience engagement.

The atmosphere was casual but still professional. There were outdoor lights that made the setting look as if it felt warm and welcoming as the performance continued. Behind the performers, there were extra chairs and shaded areas that made the space feel more like an outdoor lounge than a formal concert hall. Since the concert took place during the beginning of the COVID-19 pandemic, the performers were spaced apart and microphones were placed near

the instruments so the sound could be heard clearly outside. Even with these adjustments, the concert still looked organized and enjoyable.

The second concert of the Charlotte Symphony Al Fresco series opened with the Pleyel Theme and Variations for cello and double bass, performed by host and Principal Cellist Alan Black alongside bassist Jeffrey Don. Before playing, the two musicians discussed the piece and its composer, Ignaz Pleyel, whom Don described as a “second tier” Viennese Classical composer and a student of Haydn who wrote inventively for the double bass. The work, composed around 1810 or 1811, drew on the distinct sonic properties of both instruments. Don pointed out that one variation features simultaneous double stops in both parts, creating the impression of four players rather than two.

Don’s use of harmonics in the final variation was the most striking moment of the opening piece. He had explained the technique beforehand, describing how touching a string lightly at specific intervals produces notes an octave or more above the open string with a chime-like quality. The double bass, he noted, is especially suited to harmonics because its longer strings make the nodes easier to locate and isolate, and this technique was common among bass players in the eighteenth century as a way of producing bell-like or horn-like tones. In performance, Don executed the harmonics cleanly, producing clear, ethereal tones that stood apart from the rest of the work in both color and character. The two musicians’ evident familiarity with each other gave the performance a calm, assured quality that came through even in an informal outdoor setting.

The piece started at a moderate and calm pace. It introduced a main theme, and then different variations of the theme were played throughout the piece. Some parts stayed calm and

peaceful, while other sections became faster and more energetic. These tempo changes helped keep the piece interesting and prevented it from sounding repetitive. The cello and double bass blended together well and created a lower-pitched sound that gave the first half of the concert a calm and relaxing mood overall.

The second half of the concert was the *Flute Quartet in D Major* by Wolfgang Amadeus Mozart. This piece created a completely different feeling from the first half of the concert. Wang spoke about the work before playing it, calling it his favorite of the Mozart flute quartets (Charlotte Symphony Al Fresco Concert Recording) and citing its energy and the particular brightness of the D major key. While the first piece had a lower and deeper sound, the Mozart quartet felt brighter, faster, and more lively. The instruments used were the flute, viola, violin, and cello, and the performers sat in a square-like arrangement while playing.

Musicological analysis of Mozart's *Flute Quartet in D Major*, K. 285 describes the work as primarily "concertante" in style, in which the flute occupies the leading role while the strings function as supportive accompaniment, creating transparent textures and clear contrasts in color and articulation (Christiansen). The texture of the quartet is mainly homophonic, ensuring that the flute's melodic line cuts through a well-defined harmonic background. Although the flute is melodically dominant, the interaction between the flute and strings remains conversational.

The first movement, *Allegro*, was rhythmically clear, while the second movement, *Adagio*, which Wang described as among the finest pages ever written for the flute, received notably careful treatment. The flute stood out the most to me during the performance because Victor Wang remained noticeable no matter how fast or slow the music became. The violin, viola, and cello helped support the performance by adding harmony and depth, but the flute

stayed as the main focus throughout the piece. The contrast between the bright sound of the flute and the lower sounds from the string instruments made the second half feel energetic and expressive. Mozart uses metrical subdivisions, supported by well defined phrasing, to create an energetic but controlled musical character in the Allegro. The Adagio contrasts this with long, lyrical phrases that emphasize expressive tone and sustained melodic development. As a Classical period work, the quartet reflects Mozart's emphasis on clarity, balance, and structured melodic development.

Wang performed with a Win-d-fender attached to his instrument, a device designed for outdoor flute playing that redirects the player's airstream upward rather than outward. According to the manufacturer, "WINDEFENDER installs easily and safely secures to the flute, shielding the lip plate from all directions while not interfering with the player's air stream" (Flute Specialists). During the pandemic, the device also addressed concerns about aerosol dispersal specific to flutists, whose airstream exits across the instrument rather than into a mouthpiece. Wang noted beforehand that his primary concern had been whether the device would affect his tone quality, and he reported that it had not. Black confirmed this observation afterward, stating that the sound was indistinguishable from what Wang would normally produce. Maintaining that level of performance while adapting to both the outdoor environment and the safety demands of the period was no small task.

The setup during the second half stayed similar to the first half. The concert was still performed outdoors, and the cello continued to have a microphone nearby so the sound could project clearly. It can also be inferred that the concert was virtual because there did not appear to be a live audience, and the violin, viola, and cello players wore masks during the performance

because of COVID-19 guidelines in 2020. Even though the performance was socially distanced, the musicians still played together smoothly and professionally.

Overall, I thought the concert was enjoyable and well organized. I liked how the two halves had different moods and sounds because it kept the concert interesting. *Theme and Variations for Bass and Cello* created a calmer and deeper atmosphere, while Mozart's *Flute Quartet in D Major* brought more energy and brightness to the performance. The flute stood out the most to me during the second half because of how clearly it carried the melody. I also thought the outdoor setting and socially distanced setup made the concert feel unique since it reflected how performances had to adapt during the COVID-19 pandemic. Overall, I would consider seeing this concert in person because I enjoyed the music and the atmosphere of the performance.

Works Cited:

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